BioCap Project Communication Induction & Stakeholder Consultation Workshop Report.

5th to 6th March 2026

Hotel de Mille Collines, Kigali



Group photo of all the participants

Introduction:

The BioCap Project aims to strengthen Rwanda's institutional and human capacity in crop biotechnology research, biosafety coordination, and public communication. Under the AfS-Rwanda sub-grant, and in close partnership with RAB and CIP, the 2026 work plan prioritizes structured, evidence-based communication around three key biotechnology crops: potato, cassava, and banana; all of which are central to Rwanda's food security agenda and ongoing research programs.

As part of this effort, a high-level Communication Induction and Stakeholder Consultation Workshop was convened to bring together core implementing partners. In particularly CIP and RAB, alongside international BioCap partners who joined virtually were able to interact with AfS-Rwanda team but also 3rd party and consultant organization like Radio La Bnenevolencija that will work with AfS-Rwanda Drama Series deliverable and Rwanda Media Commission (RMC) involved in the planned journalists and media engagement. The workshop was designed to establish a shared understanding of the 2026 work plan, align expectations, and collectively shape the communication agenda for the year.

Aligned with BioCap Results 2.4 and 2.5, the two-day engagement served as a foundational step toward the development of the 2026 Crop Biotechnology Communication Strategy and Action Plan, which constitutes a key deliverable for the second quarter. It provided a structured platform to integrate diverse perspectives, ensuring that the strategy reflects both technical priorities and stakeholder realities.

The workshop brought together scientists, communication specialists, development partners, media representatives, and institutional stakeholders. Through a participatory and co-creation approach, participants jointly defined communication objectives, refined messaging pillars, identified priority audiences, and outlined a practical roadmap for implementation.priority audiences, and outlined a practical roadmap for implementation.

Workshop Objectives:

Overall Objective

To co-develop a validated draft framework and a detailed 2026 Communication Action Plan that will inform the final BioCap Crop Biotechnology Communication Strategy, as a key second-quarter deliverable.

Specific Objectives

- Align implementing partners, particularly RAB, CIP, and international BioCap partners, on 2026 communication priorities, deliverables, and milestones.
- Define crop-specific communication objectives for potato, cassava, and banana, including priority audiences, messaging pillars, and key sensitivities.
- Develop a structured 2026 Communication Action Plan outlining core activities, timelines, responsibilities, and expected outputs.

Workshop Proceedings:

Day 1: Internal Alignment and Technical Drafting of the 2026 Communication Strategy

Date: 5 March 2026

Opening Remarks Session

The workshop commenced with participant registration and a networking session, setting the stage for a collaborative and results-oriented engagement. In their opening remarks, Mr. Pacifique Nshimiyimana, Dr. Bellancile Uzayisenga (RAB), and Dr. Eric Magembe (CIP) collectively underscored the central role of strategic communication in advancing the BioCap Project, particularly in building public trust, enhancing stakeholder engagement, and ensuring that biotechnology research translates into societal impact.

Each speaker, representing their respective institutions, articulated clear expectations for strengthened coordination, shared accountability, and mutual support among partners. They emphasized the need for open, transparent collaboration throughout the project's implementation, positioning communication not as a standalone function, but as a unifying pillar for achieving BioCap's broader scientific and development objectives.


Mr. Pacifique Nshimiyimana (AfS-Rwa),


Dr. Eric Magembe (CIP), and


Dr. Bellancile Uzayisenga(RAB)

Participants were reminded that effective communication is essential to ensure that scientific innovations translate into real agricultural benefits for farmers and consumers.

Session on BioCap Project Overview

Dr. Eric Magembe delivered a comprehensive overview of the BioCap Project, beginning with the concept and vision that informed its design. He highlighted how the project was co-developed through a

collaborative process involving RAB, CIP, and donor partners, with a shared objective of strengthening Rwanda's capacity in crop biotechnology while addressing critical constraints facing smallholder farmers.

He emphasized that BioCap is not only a research and capacity-building initiative, but also a response to declining productivity and resilience in key staple crops; potato, cassava, and banana; due to persistent disease pressures with economic, health, and environmental implications. For potato, bacterial wilt and late blight continue to reduce yields and farmer incomes; cassava faces threats such as cassava brown streak disease affecting both food safety and marketability; while banana production is constrained by diseases like banana bacterial wilt, undermining a crop central to nutrition and livelihoods. Through biotechnology, the project aims to restore the productivity, resilience, and profitability of these crops by enabling farmers to access improved, high-quality planting materials.

Dr. Magembe also presented the 2026 approved work plan, expected deliverables, and the reporting and coordination mechanisms guiding implementation. He clarified how communication activities directly contribute to Result 2.4 (enhancing stakeholder trust and engagement) and Result 2.5 (strengthening biosafety coordination and regulatory communication), positioning communication as a strategic enabler of impact.



Dr. Eric Magembe presenting an overview of the BioCap Project to the audience of partners' staff Session on Social Media Campaigns

The session concluded with a brief Q&A, where participants sought clarification on roles, expectations, and timelines. In closing, Dr. Magembe called on participants to "gear up their sleeves" and work closely with AfS-Rwanda to co-develop a robust and persuasive crop biotechnology communication strategy, one that not only supports the deployment of improved seed systems, but, most importantly, fosters public trust and drives farmer adoption.

Session on Social Media and Digital Communication for Biotechnology

Mr. Alex Nyandwi delivered an engaging session on social media best practices and their strategic role in reaching large and diverse audiences while fostering trust through fact-based, responsible communication. He emphasized that social media is not only a dissemination tool, but a critical space for shaping perceptions—requiring accuracy, consistency, and credibility to effectively support public understanding of crop biotechnology.



Mr. Alexis Nyandwi highlighting the role of social media influencers

Drawing from his experience as the winner of the OFAB Rwanda Chapter Digital Content Creation category, Mr. Nyandwi showcased practical examples of impactful campaigns, demonstrating how well-structured, evidence-driven content can strike the right balance between accessibility and scientific integrity. He highlighted that successful digital engagement goes beyond visibility to influence attitudes and behaviors, ultimately contributing to the adoption of improved technologies.

Together with a team of social media influencers, including Ms. Shimo and Ms. Grace from AfS-Rwanda's Voices of AgriBiotech group, the session further outlined plans to build on the strong momentum established under RABP-CMP and OFAB initiatives. They noted that previous efforts have already contributed to more positive, fact-based narratives around crop biotechnology online, and emphasized the importance of scaling these efforts through coordinated, consistent, and audience-centered digital strategies.

Session on Communication Strategy Framework (2025–2029)

This session was facilitated by Mr. Moses Kazoora, a communication consultant supporting AfS-Rwanda in the development of the BioCap Communication Strategy, with extensive experience from reputable institutions including the Rwanda Social Security Board (RSSB) and the African Development Bank (AfDB). He guided participants through the proposed structure of the BioCap Communication Strategy (2025–2029), emphasizing the need for a clear, results-oriented framework that ensures consistency, credibility, and impact in messaging across all project interventions.

The discussion focused on aligning the strategy with BioCap's Results Framework, particularly Result 2.4 on stakeholder trust and engagement. Mr. Kazoora elaborated on how the strategy should articulate measurable outcomes, strengthen capacity-building efforts under Output 2.4.2, and deliver targeted communication products and outreach activities under Output 2.4.3. He stressed the importance of translating technical research outputs into accessible, audience-centered messages that can drive understanding, trust, and ultimately adoption.

Participants actively engaged in refining the strategic direction, ensuring that the framework reflects both institutional priorities and practical implementation realities, while positioning communication as a core pillar for achieving BioCap's long-term impact.



Mr. Moses Kazoora defining the structure of the BioCap Communication Strategy

Session on Communication Action Planning

Facilitated by Mr. Pacifique Nshimiyimana, this highly interactive session translated the strategic framework into practical, crop-specific communication actions. Participants engaged in a plenary discussion centered on the three priority crops**;** potato, cassava, and banana; with a focus on aligning scientific progress with targeted communication approaches for 2026.

The session explored key scientific milestones expected in 2026, identified priority audiences, including farmers, policymakers, regulators, media, youth, and consumers; and defined core messaging pillars

tailored to each crop. Particular attention was given to anticipating potential risks and misinformation, as well as selecting the most effective communication channels and tools to ensure reach, clarity, and impact.

Participants were then organized into crop-specific working groups, where they undertook a practical exercise on **audience persona development**. This exercise enabled each group to profile their target audiences in terms of behaviors, information needs, perceptions, and preferred communication channels. Building on this, groups identified best practices for effectively reaching and engaging each audience segment, ensuring that communication efforts are both evidence-based and audience-centered.



Group Discussion photo

The groups proceeded to draft initial messaging frameworks and outline priority communication activities. The day concluded with a joint wrap-up session, where each group shared preliminary insights and aligned on key elements to be further refined and presented on the following day.



Discussions in working groups (3 groups working on drafting messaging frameworks and communication activities focusing on one of the priority crops)

Day 2: Stakeholder Consultation and Communication Co-Creation

Date: 6th of March 2026

Opening and Recap Session

The second day commenced with welcome remarks from Mr. Pacifique Nshimiyimana, who outlined the objectives of the day and emphasized the critical role of stakeholder participation in ensuring that the BioCap Communication Strategy reflects the needs, expectations, and realities of the broader biotechnology ecosystem. He highlighted that this phase of the workshop was essential for validating and enriching the draft communication approaches through inclusive consultation and co-creation.



Mr. Pacifique, Country Director of AfS-Rwanda delivering welcome remarks on Day2

Mr. Pacifique also welcomed RAB staff participating in the BioCap program, particularly candidates preparing for the Michigan State University program, and encouraged their active engagement throughout the day. He introduced a dedicated breakout session aimed at capturing their professional profiles for digital communication and visibility purposes, reinforcing the importance of positioning scientists as credible voices in biotechnology communication.

In addition, he introduced key third-party collaborators supporting the communication agenda, notably Radio La Benevolencija (RLB), represented by Mr. Charles Lwanga Rukundo. He underscored the strategic role of RLB in delivering drama-based communication interventions under the project, and encouraged participants to closely follow the upcoming presentation to draw lessons from the successful Musekeweya drama series, previously implemented in partnership with AfS-Rwanda, which effectively drove behavior change and technology adoption, in areas such as solar energy in rural and remote communities.

Following the opening remarks, a recap of Day 1 outcomes was presented by Dr. Aimable Nsanzinshuti. He highlighted key agreements reached on messaging pillars, priority audiences, and communication objectives. In his capacity as Monitoring and Evaluation lead at AfS-Rwanda, Dr. Aimable also outlined the framework and protocols that will guide the measurement of outputs, outcomes, and overall impact of the communication strategy, setting a results-oriented tone for the day's deliberations.



Dr. Aimable Nsanzishuti presenting on Day1's key outcomes on messaging pillars, audiences, and communication objectives.

Session on Benchmarking Case Studies on Behaviour Change Communication

This session presented practical case studies to illustrate effective approaches to behaviour change communication, with a focus on translating complex scientific concepts into accessible, trusted, and actionable messages for diverse audiences.

a. Behaviour Change Through Radio Drama Series

Mr. Charles Lwanga Rukundo from Radio La Benevolencija (RLB) delivered a compelling presentation on the *Musekeweya* radio drama series, showcasing how storytelling can be strategically used to drive behaviour change at scale. He demonstrated how serialized drama formats simplify complex and technical subjects, such as new technologies, by embedding them within relatable narratives, characters, and everyday community experiences.



Mr. Charles Lwanga(Radio La Benevolentia) presented the Musekewera radio drama series

The approach fosters emotional connection, sustained audience engagement, and gradual learning, leading to long-term shifts in attitudes and practices. Drawing from RLB's collaboration with AfS-Rwanda, he highlighted how such formats have successfully supported technology awareness and adoption, particularly in rural and hard-to-reach communities.

b. Media and Fact-Based Journalism

Mr. Emmanuel Mugisha from the Rwanda Media Commission presented on the critical role of mainstream media in shaping public understanding and addressing misinformation around biotechnology. He emphasized the need to strengthen journalists' capacity to report accurately on scientific topics, promote evidence-based narratives, and build trust with audiences. The session underscored the importance of sustained collaboration between scientists, communication experts, and media institutions to ensure that biotechnology is communicated responsibly, clearly, and credibly to the public.



Mr. Emmanuel Mugisha(RMC) discusses the role of mainstream media and fact-based journalism in addressing misinformation.

In closing, Mr. Emmanuel Mugisha, the Executive Secretary of RMC, grounded his presentation in practical experience by drawing on previous and ongoing collaborations between the Rwanda Media Commission (RMC) and AfS-Rwanda under the OFAB platform. He highlighted how these initiatives have successfully

advanced media engagement on biotechnology through targeted journalist trainings, sustained mentorship, and the promotion of fact-based reporting.

Emphasizing the importance of equipping media professionals with the right knowledge and tools, Mr. Emmanuel also underscored that credible, science-driven journalism, supported by strong collaboration between scientists and media institutions, makes an essential pillar for countering misinformation, building public trust, and enabling informed discourse around crop biotechnology

Together, the two case studies reinforced the value of combining innovative communication formats with strong media engagement to effectively influence perceptions, build trust, and support the adoption of new technologies.

Session on International Partner Contributions with virtual Participation

International partners, including Michigan State University (MSU), represented by Dr. Callista Rakhamatov, and the International Institute of Tropical Agriculture (IITA), represented by Dr. Rose Okech Harriet, joined virtually to share their perspectives and expectations on the BioCap communication agenda. Their contributions emphasized the importance of product-based communication that clearly articulates the value, performance, and real-life benefits of biotech crops for farmers and consumers.



Mr. Pacifique facilitating a Virtual Session Via Zoom and in-person participants

Beyond expectations, the partners actively contributed to shaping key messaging directions; highlighting the need to present both the Centre of Excellence in Crop Biotechnology and crop-specific innovations in a clear, credible, and relatable manner. They stressed that communication efforts must proactively address

misconceptions while reinforcing a strong, unifying narrative grounded in ownership and relevance: *"African crops, improved by African scientists, for Africans and smallholder farmers."*

The session reinforced the importance of coordinated messaging across partners to ensure consistency, credibility, and a shared vision in communicating the impact of the BioCap Project.

Break-out session on Detailed 2026 Communication & Messaging Action Plan

Participants were divided into two thematic working groups and introduced to a Communication Matrix tool designed to guide the development of clear, targeted, and audience-specific messaging. The exercise focused on defining and customizing messages for both primary and secondary audiences, ensuring that communication outputs are relevant, coherent, and impactful. This practical session enabled participants to directly contribute to the core structure and content of the Crop Biotechnology Communication Strategy Document currently under development.

- Group 1 focused on product-based communication for the priority crops, potato, cassava, and banana, working to articulate value propositions, benefits, and key messages tailored to different stakeholder groups.
- Group 2 focused on positioning the Centre of Excellence in Crop Biotechnology, defining how to communicate its role, relevance, and contribution to Rwanda's agricultural transformation.

Across both groups, participants identified and prioritized a range of communication key messaging for the secondary audiences, they learnt how paramount it is to have both primary and secondary audience thought through in designing impactful message. The session reinforced the importance of structured, audience-centered communication planning as a foundation for effective outreach and long-term impact.

Break-out Session on Interviews with MSU Program Candidate Profiling

This session highlighted the strategic importance of human capital development within the BioCap Project, emphasizing that the long-term sustainability of its impact, particularly the operationalization of the Centre of Excellence in Crop Biotechnology, will depend on the capacity, visibility, and leadership of RAB professionals trained under the MSU program.

The AfS-Rwanda communication team conducted in-depth interviews with RAB-nominated MSU program candidates to document their professional journeys, expertise, and motivations in advancing crop biotechnology. The session underscored that beyond technical training, profiling these scientists is essential to positioning them as credible voices and champions of biotechnology, capable of driving both innovation and public trust.
Four RAB staff were featured in this session: Mr. Venuste Ndagijimana (Legal Affairs Specialist), Dr. Constantin Dushimimana, Dr. Bancy Waweru, and Mrs. Anastasie Musabyemungu. Their profiles were recorded and will be published across the project's website and other digital communication platforms.

The content generated will feed into blogs, storytelling features, and social media campaigns, showcasing institutional capacity-building efforts while reinforcing the narrative that the future of crop biotechnology in Rwanda is being led by skilled national experts.



*Interviews **Candidates for MSU Program**: Dr. Bancy, Dr. Anastasie, and Dr. Costentin*

Conclusion:

The BioCap Communication Induction and Stakeholder Consultation Workshop successfully established a shared vision, strategic alignment, and a practical roadmap for advancing crop biotechnology communication in Rwanda. Through a highly participatory process that combined technical presentations, benchmarking case studies, and collaborative working sessions, partners co-developed the foundations of the 2026 Crop Biotechnology Communication Strategy, anchored on the priority crops of potato, cassava, and banana, and aligned with BioCap Results 2.4 and 2.5.

Beyond framework development, the workshop reinforced the central role of strategic, evidence-based, and audience-centered communication in driving adoption, addressing misconceptions, and building sustained public trust. It also highlighted the importance of institutional collaboration and human capacity development**,** particularly through the profiling and empowerment of RAB scientists and MSU program candidates, as key drivers of long-term impact and sustainability for the Centre of Excellence in Crop Biotechnology.

The outcomes of this engagement provide not only a coordinated communication pathway, but also a strong coalition of partners committed to delivering consistent, credible, and impactful messaging. Moving forward, these efforts will be instrumental in ensuring that biotechnology innovations are well understood, trusted, and ultimately adopted by farmers and the wider public, contributing to resilient food systems and agricultural transformation in Rwanda.

End!